Practical guide + checklist

The PSTN Switch-Off

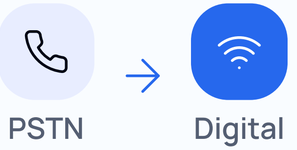
What your business needs to check before 31 January 2027

A practical readiness guide to hidden legacy connections, migration risk and what to do next.



The switch-off in 60 seconds

31 January 2027 is the deadline



31 January 2027

Deadline: the old network is retired

350,000

UK business premises still operating on the old analogue network

The UK's traditional Public Switched Telephone Network (PSTN) is being retired. Openreach estimates that around 350,000 UK business premises are still operating on the old analogue network.

The change is bigger than traditional landline calls. Any service or equipment that still relies on a legacy phone line needs to be identified, checked and moved to a suitable digital alternative where required.

> Don't just ask: "Have we moved our phones?" Ask: "Is anything across our organisation still relying on the old network?"

The hidden connections

Your phones may already be digital. That doesn't mean you're finished.

Legacy connections often sit behind equipment that nobody thinks of as "telecoms". Some were installed years ago, inherited with a building or managed by a completely different team.



"If nobody can tell you what an old line does, don't assume it does nothing."

Do you know what's still connected across your organisation?

Fire & security alarms

Signalling paths may still rely on legacy analogue connections.

Lift emergency phones

Dedicated lift lines can sit outside the main telephony estate.

Door entry & intercoms

Older systems may still dial out or communicate over a phone line.

CCTV & security systems

Legacy monitoring functions can depend on older connectivity.

Card terminals & EPOS

Older payment and till equipment may still rely on traditional lines.

Fax machines

An obvious PSTN dependency that is easy to forget when it is rarely used.

Remote monitoring & telemetry

Meters, plant and machine-to-machine systems can sit quietly on legacy connections.

Broadband & backup connectivity

Some older services retain a technical dependency on the legacy network.

Other connected equipment

Vending, franking, printers and specialist equipment can also need checking.

Why hidden dependencies get missed

The line may sit with IT. The device may not.

Communications providers can tell you which services they supply, but they may not know what equipment is connected at your premises. That is why a proper readiness check needs to go wider than the telecoms bill.

Multi-site

Repeat the exercise at every location. One site's setup does not prove another site is clear — especially where buildings, landlords or local suppliers differ.

Who else should you ask?

Ask	They may know about
IT / telecoms	Voice services, broadband, line inventory, routers, network dependencies.
Facilities / Estates	Lifts, fire systems, building controls, intercoms, inherited building services.
Security	Intruder alarms, CCTV, access control and monitored security systems.
Finance / Operations / Retail	Payment terminals, EPOS, fax, franking and operational devices.
Site managers	Local equipment, old sockets, one-off lines and supplier-managed systems that central teams may not see.
Landlords / specialist suppliers	Shared-building services and equipment maintained outside your own IT team.

What happens when one dependency gets missed

The risk isn't just "the phone line stops".

A missed dependency can turn into an operational problem very quickly. The technical fault is only the first step; the expensive part is often the investigation, coordination and urgent remediation that follows.



"The cheapest issue to fix is the one you find before it becomes urgent."

Where it can show up

- Payment terminal
- Lift call
- Alarm signal
- Door access
- Monitoring alert

One overlooked connection can become:

1. A device or service loses its connection
2. A payment, alert, emergency call, access or monitoring path no longer works as expected
3. Staff have to investigate what failed and who owns it
4. Suppliers and engineers are pulled in urgently
5. The business absorbs avoidable downtime, internal time, emergency costs and customer impact

Power resilience

Digital services depend on local power and connectivity. If a lift phone, alarm or other critical site function must remain available during a power cut, resilience needs to be designed into the migration — not discovered afterwards.

What to check now

Seven checks to run before the switch-off.

1. **Get the full line list** — Ask your communications provider(s) for a complete list of active services across every site — not just the numbers you recognise.
2. **Walk every site** — Look for anything connected to a phone socket or legacy line: phones, alarms, lifts, access, payments, monitoring and older equipment.
3. **Ask beyond IT** — Check with Facilities, Estates, Security, Finance, Operations and local site teams for systems you may not own centrally.
4. **Give every line and device an owner** — Record what it does, where it is, who supports it and which supplier or contract it belongs to.
5. **Confirm compatibility** — Ask the equipment manufacturer or specialist supplier whether the device will work correctly after migration and what needs changing.
6. **Plan migration and resilience** — Decide what will be upgraded, replaced or retired — and what must keep working during a power or connectivity outage.
7. **Migrate, test and document** — Do not sign the work off until every affected service has been tested and the final estate is documented.

Red flag: If a line is active and nobody can explain what it does, treat it as unresolved until you can prove otherwise.

Six questions to ask any migration provider

Don’t just ask for a VoIP quote. Ask how they will prove nothing was missed.

	Ask this	Why it matters
1	Will you audit the whole estate or only replace our main phone service?	You need to know whether ancillary lines and non-voice devices are in scope.
2	How will you identify unknown or poorly documented lines?	A provider should have a clear process for tracing, validating and escalating anything nobody recognises.
3	Who is responsible for checking each connected device?	Confirm whether they liaise with alarm, lift, payment or equipment suppliers — or whether that sits with you.
4	What happens to broadband and other connectivity dependencies?	Make sure legacy connectivity is reviewed alongside voice rather than treated as a separate afterthought.
5	How will you handle services that need resilience during a power or connectivity outage?	Critical systems need an explicit continuity plan.
6	What exactly will be tested and documented before sign-off?	A migration is not complete because the new service is live; affected devices and processes need proving.

Be wary

If the proposal is mostly about handsets and call packages but nobody asks about sites, ancillary devices, ownership, resilience or testing, the scope may be too narrow.

“A good provider should be able to explain what changes, who owns each step and how you’ll know it worked.”



How PAS helps

Found a gap? You don't need to start another supplier search from scratch.

Project Advisory Solutions (PAS) is an independent IT advisory and sourcing service. We help businesses clarify what needs fixing, then connect them with vetted telecoms providers suited to the requirement.

There is no charge to your business for our sourcing or introduction service. Our commercial relationship is with the provider.

How it works

1

Tell us what needs sorting

Share what you have found, what is still unclear and any sites or systems that may be affected.

2

We find the right fit

We identify relevant providers from the network we have already researched and vetted, then assess fit against your requirement.

3

We make the introduction

You speak directly with the provider, decide whether they are right and take the project forward if you choose to.

The pay-off

Less time searching and comparing suppliers. Less internal resource tied up in procurement. Less risk of rushing into a poor-fit provider as the deadline gets closer.

Not 100% sure you're covered?

If this guide has raised a question, or you've found something that still needs sorting, let's keep the conversation going.

Get in touch about the PSTN switch-off →

Or email us directly at:
contact@projectadvisorysolutions.com

Tell us what you're dealing with and we'll take it from there. We'll help you work out the right next step and, where relevant, connect you with a suitable vetted provider. You only deal commercially with a provider if you decide to proceed.

